

PITFALLS OF TOO MANY TOURISTS Without proper regulation of footfalls, a daily average of 1,000 tourists visit the caves. The excess humidity and high CO_2 from human breath is a major reason for the deterioration of the murals in the cave complex

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tion. Some 400,000 tourists visited Ajanta every year over 2008-18, and the dial is springing back to that gently rising curve post-pandemic. Even in lean season, driver Rajendra Bhope does 10 trips on his shuttle bus for tourists from the "T-point"—six buses suffice in February. In peak season, over a hundred people crowd into caves that, since 1985, are supposed to hold a maximum of 40 at any given time. That creates a semi-permanent microclimate: humidity and carbon dioxide levels ride high. "Humans emit bodily gases that contain volatile organic compounds (VOCs), which affect the pigments," says a scientist at the National Environmental Engineering Research Institute (NEERI), which has done a series of studies at Ajanta. Heat from tungsten, mercury and halogen lighting kept up a state of microburn for decades. Rising acidity in rainwater eats away at exposed rock outside; hairline flaws in the rock, difficult to trace even with advanced geo-tracking, let in seepage. A whole symphony, in short, of corrosive organic and inorganic phenomena, wreaking subtle chemical alterations, enabling microbiotic capture (see *Why the Murals are Degrading*). Stack on to this the sheer range of effects accomplished by the human hand over the past two centuries, from active mutilation to benign neglect to well-meaning solecisms. That's why mural specialist Sanjay Dhar, asked to grade the degree of peril on a scale of one to 10, pauses only to confirm that 10 represents the most extreme. Then says, simply: "10."

CONSERVATOR'S DREAM, AND NIGHTMARE

It's not a crisis immediately obvious to the naked eye, as you wade past the hushed entry rituals that signal a special zone: parking a couple of miles away, shuttle buses carting a global ethnic smorgasbord, baggage check. Some things find ways to continue, like water finds its way through